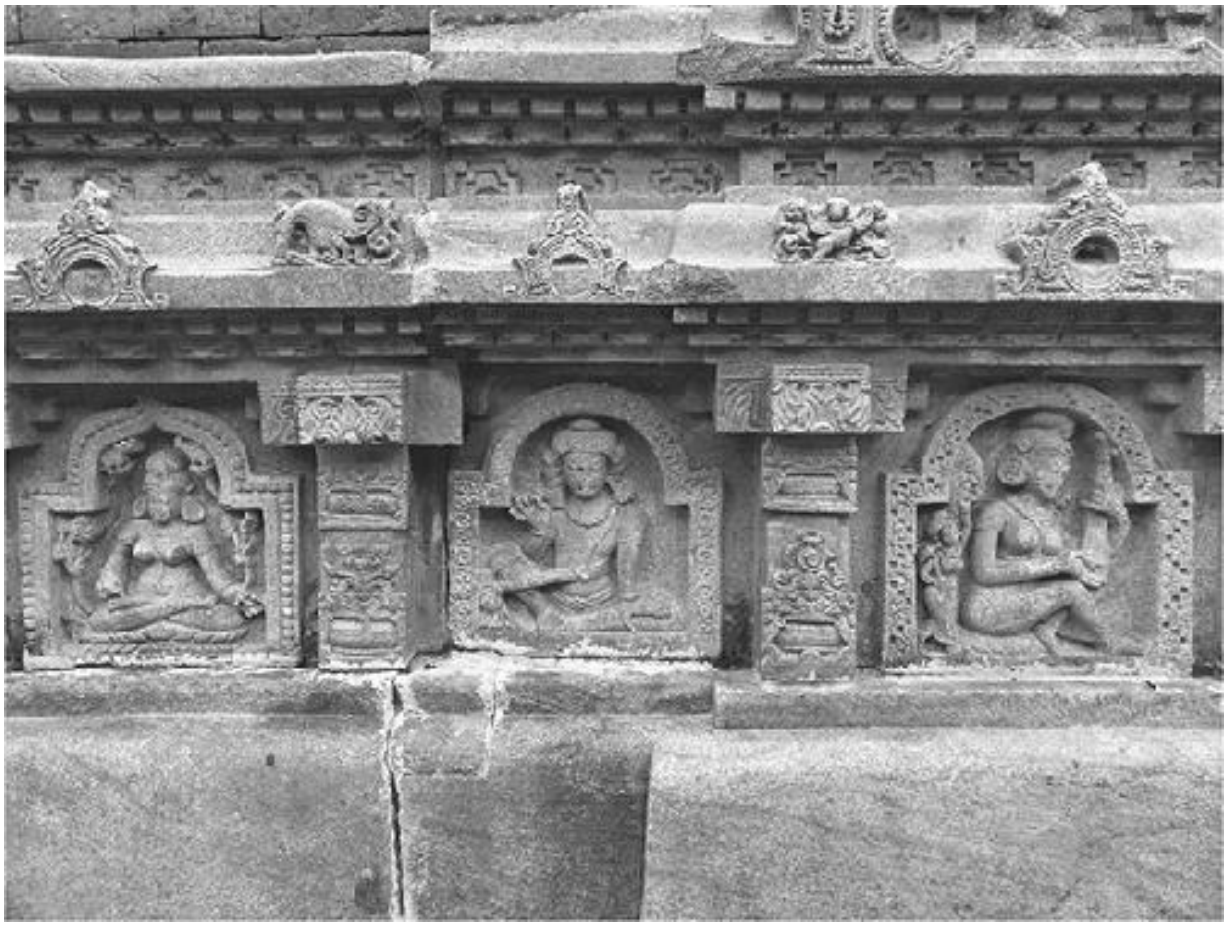


Figure 6. Outer wall of a temple at Nalanda

What the Monks Studied

An abiding interest in language and its relationship to reality was a prominent feature of mid-first millennium scholastic Indian philosophy. How does the structure of language impact our understanding of the world? Does language correspond to an objective, mind-independent reality? On what grounds can we establish the truth? Subjects of central concern included linguistics and its various aspects—phonology (study of speech sounds), morphology (study of words), semantics (study of meaning)—as well as epistemology, metaphysics, logic and ethics. However, the curriculum had little or no emphasis on politics, geometry, mathematics and physics, which may have opened up a different way of comprehending the nature of reality, as it did in ancient Greece. But many other sciences were